

VERIQO Evidence Dossier Guide

How to read a VERIQO Evidence Dossier — written for the person receiving one, who may be an adjuster, a broker, counsel, an arbitrator, or a counterparty with no reason to trust whoever sent it.

1. What you have been given

A dossier is the complete, self-contained record of one case: the evidence it rests on, the decision reached, the authorization to act, and the cryptographic material needed to check all of it.

It comes in two forms of the same content:

- **Human form** — readable JSON or rendered Markdown/PDF. What you read.
- **Machine form** — a `.zip` "Machine Package". What you *verify*.

If you were sent only the human form and the matter is contested, ask for the machine form. The readable document is a rendering; the package is the thing that can be checked.

2. Check it before you read it

Before drawing any conclusion from a dossier's contents, verify it:

```
veriqo-commercial-verify -package case.zip
```

Exit code `0` means every check passed. Exit `1` means at least one check failed — **stop and raise it**; a dossier that fails verification should not be relied upon.

Read the `SKIP` lines, not just the verdict. A `SKIP` means a check could not be performed with what you were given — most commonly signature verification, which needs a trusted key registry you obtained independently. A dossier that verifies with signatures skipped is *intact*, not *authenticated*. See the Unified Verifier Specification.

The verifier is a separate binary that reads only your file. It does not contact the sender's servers, which is precisely why its answer is worth something.

3. What each section tells you

Case identity

Two identifiers, and the difference matters:

- **scope** — the case ID as the submitting party named it. Their reference, meaningful in their system.
- **case_id** — the Decision's own finding hash. A cryptographic identity derived from the case's content. Two dossiers with the same `case_id` describe the same decision; a dossier whose contents were altered cannot keep the same one.

Cite the `case_id` when corresponding about a specific dossier.

Evidence inventory

Every item the decision rests on, each with its identity, provenance, integrity, custody chain, source, timing, trust classification, and domain metadata. See the Evidence Model document for what each facet means.

What to look at first:

- **state** — should be `FINALIZED`. Only finalized evidence can ground a decision.
- **verified** — re-derived at generation time, not a stored flag.
- **custody** — the ordered chain. Look at who handled the item and when. A short chain is not suspicious; an *inconsistent* one is.
- **sha256** — if you hold the underlying document, hash it yourself and compare. This is the step that connects the paper in your hand to the record in the dossier, and nobody else can do it for you.
- **signature** — **absent means unsigned**. It is not concealed; it is simply not there. Do not read an unsigned record as an authenticated one.

Corroboration and contradictions

Derived from the actual grounded finding, not written prose: `corroboration` lists evidence supporting the hypothesis; `contradictions` lists evidence against it.

A populated `contradictions` list is a sign of a well-kept record, not a weak case. The system records contradicting evidence because real matters contain it. A dossier from a contested case with an empty contradictions list deserves a question about what was submitted, not automatic confidence.

Decision

The outcome, the rationale, the logical time it was decided, and the hashes binding it to its finding and authorization. The decision is once-only: a case cannot be re-decided, so there is no possibility of a quietly revised conclusion. A changed view requires a new case, which leaves both records standing.

Action authorization and receipt

Present when the case was acted upon. Records who was authorized to do what, under which policy reference, within which validity window, and who actually executed it. Authorization and execution are separate gates: an execution outside what the authorization covers is refused, not logged as an exception.

Limitations

Always present, and the section to read most carefully. It states what this dossier does *not* establish. It is not boilerplate to skip — it is where the document tells you the boundary of its own claims, including that it takes no legal position.

Package hash and signature

`package_hash` is computed over every field except itself and the signature. `package_signature`, when present, is a real Ed25519 signature over that hash. Absent means unsigned.

4. What a verified dossier does and does not establish

It does establish, when verification passes:

- The record is internally consistent and unaltered since generation.
- Each evidence item's manifest is unaltered and its custody chain is unbroken.

- The decision and authorization hashes the dossier claims genuinely appear in the ledger the verifier parsed independently.
- The ledger's own hash chain is intact from genesis — no record was inserted, removed, reordered, or edited.
- With a trusted key registry: which key attested to the record, and that the key was not revoked.

It does not establish:

- That the underlying documents are **truthful**. A surveyor's report can be intact, in custody, signed — and wrong. Integrity is not veracity.
- That asserted identities (vessel, party, policy) were checked against an authoritative external registry. They were recorded as asserted.
- That the decision was **correct**, only that it followed from the recorded inputs and cited real, finalized evidence.
- Anything about **legal admissibility or evidential weight**. See the Legal Positioning Statement and the Jurisdiction Disclaimer.

5. Practical checks for a recipient

1. Verify the package. Record the exit code and the full check output — including `SKIP` lines — with your file.
2. Hash any underlying document you hold; compare to `sha256`.
3. Read Limitations before Conclusions.
4. Check the evidence timing against your own account of events. Ticks are logical, not wall-clock, so ask the sender for the tick-to-date mapping if sequence matters to your position.
5. If signatures were skipped and authenticity matters, ask the sender for their trusted key registry through a channel independent of the dossier itself, then re-verify.
6. Keep the `.zip`. It stays verifiable indefinitely with no VERIQO service reachable and no licence in force.

6. If verification fails

A `FAIL` is a substantive finding. Do not discard the package and do not quietly re-request a "fixed" one — the failing artifact is itself evidence about the record's handling.

Record which check failed, keep the original file unmodified, and raise it with the sender in writing. `ledger_hash_chain` and `lineage_decision` failures are materially more serious than a single evidence-item failure: they indicate the record as a whole does not hang together, rather than one item being damaged.